MFA codes rejected or push notifications not arriving

Article KB0010009 | Owner: Identity & Access Management | Subcategory: MFA / authenticator | Applies to: Windows 11 laptops (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 MacBook Pro/Air, iOS and Android smartphones with Microsoft Authenticator, Any device connecting via Acme VPN (GlobalProtect) or Microsoft 365 services

Summary

Users may experience MFA push notifications not arriving or verification codes being rejected when using Microsoft Authenticator. This article guides end-users through self-help steps to re-enroll their authenticator and helps service-desk agents reset MFA registration or issue a temporary access pass.

Symptoms

- Push notification from Microsoft Authenticator does not appear on the phone
- Authenticator shows a 6-digit code but the sign-in page reports "Invalid verification code"
- Authenticator app displays the message "Account not found" or shows a different account
- After getting a new phone, the old Authenticator still tries to approve sign-ins
- Phone time is incorrect and codes are rejected as "Code expired"

Common causes

- Device replaced or restored without transferring the Authenticator credential
- Backup authentication method (SMS) not enabled or phone number changed
- Phone clock drift causing time-based one-time passwords to be out of sync
- Authenticator app data corrupted or account removed accidentally
- User locked out after 5 failed MFA attempts, triggering a temporary lockout

Preliminary Checks

Before contacting the service desk, verify that the device has internet connectivity, that the Microsoft Authenticator app is installed and up to date, and that the phone's date and time are set to automatic network time. Also confirm that you can receive SMS messages to the number registered for backup MFA.

Self-Help Procedure: Re-enroll Microsoft Authenticator

If you have a new phone, lost access to the old device, or the authenticator is not generating valid codes, you can reset your MFA registration yourself using the self-service portal. After identity verification you will receive a QR code to scan with the Authenticator app on your new device.

1. Go to the Acme self-service password reset portal at https://passwordreset.acme.example and click \"Register or update my multi-factor authentication\".
2. Sign in with your Acme email address and password; you will be prompted for MFA - choose the backup SMS method if available, otherwise answer your security questions.
3. On the MFA registration page, select \"Delete my current Authenticator registration\" and confirm.
4. Choose \"Set up Microsoft Authenticator\" and display the QR code.
5. On your smartphone, install or open Microsoft Authenticator, tap \"Add account\" -> \"Work or school account\" -> \"Scan QR code\", then point the camera at the code shown on the screen.
6. Approve the push notification that appears on the phone to finish registration; you will see a confirmation that MFA is now active.

Service Desk Agent Procedure - MFA Reset / Temporary Access Pass

Agents follow this procedure after verifying the user's identity via phone or Teams chat. Depending on the situation, either clear the existing MFA registration and let the user re-enroll, or issue a Temporary Access Pass (TAP) for immediate access while the user sets up a new device.

1. Verify the caller's identity using the standard ID&AM verification script (ask for employee ID, date of birth, and recent password change).
2. Open the Microsoft Entra ID admin center, locate the user, and select \"Authentication methods\".
3. If the user has a working backup SMS method, choose \"Reset MFA registration\" and confirm; inform the user to

re-enroll Authenticator via the self-service portal.
4. If the user cannot receive SMS or has lost the phone, select \"Create Temporary Access Pass\", set the desired lifetime (e.g., 1 hour), and copy the pass.
5. Communicate the TAP to the user via a secure channel (Teams chat or phone) and instruct them to sign in at https://mysignins.microsoft.com/security-info using the pass.
6. Once the user signs in with the TAP, guide them to add a new Microsoft Authenticator registration and delete the TAP after successful enrollment.
7. Document the action in the ticket, including verification steps taken and any passes issued.

Verification - Confirm MFA Works

After completing the self-help or agent-led steps, the user should test MFA by signing into a Microsoft 365 service (e.g., Outlook on the web) and confirming that a push notification arrives or a valid 6-digit code is accepted. Successful login indicates the issue is resolved.

1. Open a browser and navigate to https://outlook.office.com.
2. Enter your Acme email address and password.
3. When prompted for MFA, check your phone for a push notification from Microsoft Authenticator or open the app to view the 6-digit code.
4. Approve the notification or enter the code and select \"Sign in\".
5. Verify that you reach your inbox without further prompts; if you see an error, repeat the enrollment steps or contact the service desk.

When to escalate

If the L1 service desk cannot verify the user's identity, the user reports continued MFA failure after following the self-help steps, or there is indication of a compromised account, escalate to the Identity & Access Management (IAM) team. Include in the escalation: the user's employee ID and email, a summary of verification steps already performed, the specific error messages observed, device model and OS version, whether backup SMS is enabled, and any Temporary Access Pass that was issued or requested.

Keywords: MFA, Authenticator, push notification, verification code, invalid code, new phone, lost phone, time sync, backup SMS, temporary access pass, TAP, identity verification, self-service password reset, Microsoft Entra ID, Azure AD